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Governing via AI Broadcasting in the Digital Era: The Policy Discourse of the Chinese Government and the Ideological Production of the CCTV AI Gala

A thesis presented

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Abstract

This study focuses on how artificial intelligence (AI) simultaneously promotes technological innovation and implements ideological management in China's state media and policy institutions. It is incorporated into a national discourse system in which the state attempts to combine economic development goals with ideological control. This thesis borrows Fairclough's three-dimensional critical discourse analysis (CDA) framework and uses NVivo to conduct a quantitative analysis of keyword frequency and co-occurrence relationships. The research materials include three core policy documents: the "New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan" issued in 2017, the "Guiding Opinions on Intelligent Broadcasting" in 2018, and the "Interim Measures for the Management of Generative Artificial Intelligence Services" issued in 2023. In addition, the "AI Gala" broadcast by CCTV is analyzed, a media event with national identity as the background and AI as the theme. The study finds that a unified language structure is formed between these texts and programs, with repeated emphasis on keywords such as "intelligent broadcasting", "strategic technology" and "cultural confidence", demonstrating the state's clear intention to promote technological nationalism. The program uses stories and visuals to convey official policies to the public through quotes from Xi Jinping's speeches, virtual AI hosts, and stage performances of algorithmic achievements. This article promotes our new understanding of technology governance, media convergence, and state power in the digital age by placing AI in China's evolving digital governance and public opinion control system.

Table of Contents

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This thesis was written during a time of academic ambition and personal loss. Despite the death of two relatives and the demands of my work, my passion for scholarship has never wavered. On the contrary, these experiences have only reinforced my belief in the power of research to preserve memory, illuminate the lost, and illuminate the complex realities we inhabit. I remain convinced that the thoughtful use of digital tools can help us better understand the world, respect our cultural heritage, and make our lives more meaningful.

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Introduction

The gradual integration of artificial intelligence (AI) and China's media management marks a new stage in the way the state's ideology is disseminated. AI is no longer just a technical tool in the factory or backstage but has also become a new weapon to shape cultural content, guide public opinion, and control public discourse. In China's digital governance system, technology platforms and political goals are closely linked (Zeng, Chan, & Schäfer, 2020; Keane & Su, 2019). As the CCP continues to strengthen its use of digital tools, AI has begun to play two roles: on the one hand, it is an operational technical tool, and on the other hand, it is a symbol of the country's modern image (Ping, 2020; Mayer-Schönberger & Zeng, 2021).

China's media has always been more than just a tool for disseminating information. It is also an important channel for government propaganda and ideological management (Zhao, 2008; Yu, 2009). Whether it is traditional print media or CCTV, the core task of media reform has always been to serve the legitimacy of the party and national unity (Shambaugh, 2007; Guo & Feng, 2012). Today, AI continues this control logic but has entered the era of algorithms. AI can automatically screen content, monitor information dissemination in real-time, and adjust content according to different users, making the communication of ideology more accurate, broader, and more targeted (Nachman, Chen, & Zhao, 2022; Jiang, Lan, Wang, & Zhang, 2023). The term "governable infrastructure" proposed by Mayer-Schönberger and Zeng (2021) is very appropriate, which emphasizes that data systems not only support governance but also construct political meaning.

The "AI Gala"[1] is the most intuitive example of this trend. It is a state-funded, televised AI-themed program that shows how technology and official media are integrated. The use of virtual AI hosts, AI-generated scripts, and performances showcasing traditional culture combine national pride and technological achievements in a visual narrative (Levy-Landesberg & Cao, 2024; Zhu & Zhong, 2024). This kind of gala is similar to the past Spring Festival Gala or National Day military parade, which is a public confirmation ceremony ofpolitical authority, but the form is more in line with today's digital communication logic (Dayan & Katz, 1992; Yu, 2009; Jiao, 2024). AI is not just a tool to imitate humans, it is also used to demonstrate the country's cultural continuity and political power. As Pan (2021) and Shi and Zhang (2024) pointed out, these large-scale communication events are now increasingly designed by algorithms and no longer rely entirely on human organization.

Three parallel policies serve as the foundation of China's AI development strategy. These policies work closely together to clarify the goals, practical uses, and boundaries of AI in cultural governance. First, the "New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan" (2017) defines AI as a "key technology" and points

[1] Full video available at: https://tv.cctv.com/2024/06/28/VIDEEt71O3OL0oJAVwvElpXV240628.shtml

out its importance to national rejuvenation, technological innovation, and social stability (State Council, 2017; Wang & Lin, 2024). Next, the "Guiding Opinions on Promoting the Development of Intelligent Broadcasting" issued in 2018 specifically describes the practical applications of AI in the broadcasting field, such as content generation, emotion recognition, and broadcasting automation (NRTA, 2018; Zhao & Phakdeephirot, 2024). Finally, the "Interim Measures for the Management of Generative Artificial Intelligence Services" (2023) established a regulatory framework for the use of AI, emphasizing that the use of AI must comply with the requirements of "positive orientation" and public safety (CAC, 2023; Sun, Hu, & Wu, 2022). Together, these three categories of policies—strategic positioning, technology promotion, and ethical protocols—constitute what Keane and Su (2019) call "digital civilization," a system that uses AI to promote national governance and cultural values.

While there is a growing body of research on AI in news reporting, information manipulation, and online platform management (Carlson, 2014; Thurman et al., 2019), there has been little attention paid to how AI is used to create and maintain ideology in China. Early researchers such as Zhao (2008) and Yu (2009) analyzed the structure of state media and the dissemination of official rituals, but they did not discuss in depth the role that AI played in these occasions. Research on media events (Dayan & Katz, 1992; Gitlin, 2002; Leo-Liu, Fung, & Fu, 2024) does mention that these activities help construct national identity, but does not explain what changes occur when rituals are dominated by algorithms. Furthermore, while research has extended to the exploration of digital surveillance (Creemers, 2020; Qiang, 2019), platform nationalism (Zhao & Lin, 2020), and "techno-orientalism" (Zeng, 2021), there is still a lack of discussion on how AI specifically participates in narrative construction and stage performance.

This study attempts to fill this gap by deeply analyzing the "AI Gala" program, which is a government-led program that combines policy propaganda, technology demonstrations, and artistic performances. The study reviews how three policy documents influence the selection and arrangement of program content. The study uses a mixed method that combines Fairclough ' s (2010) critical discourse analysis and a range of computational tools, including keyword co-occurrence, sentiment clustering, and frequency analysis (Baker et al., 2008; Zeng, 2021), to reveal how the state manages AI discourse. These policies are not only present in the text but they are also embedded in the program's visual style and emotional expression.

Based on the above analysis, this thesis proposes four theoretical contributions. First, it points out how the Chinese government uses language to shape AI into a tool of governance and cultural control. Second, it analyzes how the "AI Gala" transforms policy ideas into narrative forms and stage art that can be accepted by the audience. Third, it reveals the contradiction between official discourse and the moral, labor, and expression conflicts brought about by AI automation. Fourth, it illustrates how AI technology changes China's political communication methods and creates a new model for media rituals in the digital age. These findings enrich the discussion on political communication, platform governance, and digital authoritarianism, and also provide a specific analytical case for understanding China's media system and AI ethics.

Chapter 1 Literature Review

AI Policy and Media Governance in China

China's policy on artificial intelligence (AI) illustrates the close relationship between technological development, political management, and cultural shaping. The Communist Party of China has positioned AI as a national priority technology not only to enhance industrial competitiveness but also to strengthen national identity and maintain control over the digital space (State Council, 2017; Yang & Huang, 2022). The "New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan" issued in 2017 clearly defines the national AI strategy. The policy proposes to widely use AI in a variety of fields such as education, public security, news dissemination, and cultural content. More importantly, the plan emphasizes that AI can help China enhance its "discourse power". This means that China hopes to use AI to guide domestic public opinion and promote its values globally (Pan, 2021; Levy-Landesberg & Cao, 2024). Therefore, the plan is not only a technological development roadmap but also a political and cultural strategy document, that continues China's long-standing goal of enhancing soft power (Zhao, 2008; Keane, 2013; Billioud, 2012).

The most obvious example of how AI policy is implemented is the "Guiding Opinions on Promoting the Development of Intelligent Broadcasting" issued by the State Administration of Radio and Television (2018). The policy encourages the use of machine learning, language recognition, and content recommendation algorithms to improve work efficiency, improve the audience experience, and ensure that program content conforms to official values (NRTA, 2018; Shi & Zhang, 2024). Behind these technological applications, there are not only efficiency considerations but also political purposes. The policy requires the creation of an AI-driven content editing system that can actively identify, adjust, and strengthen narratives that conform to the core socialist values (Liu, 2024; Azahra & Suhaimi, 2024). This marks a change in the way media is regulated: from a traditional manual review to an early warning and intervention mechanism led by algorithms (Franks, Lee, & Xu, 2024; Ping, 2020).

This control mechanism reached a new height in 2023. The Interim Measures for the Administration of Generative Artificial Intelligence Services (2023) issued by the Cyberspace Administration of China stipulate that all AI-generated content must indicate the source, cannot involve politically sensitive information, and must comply with socialist moral standards (CAC, 2023). This means that China is institutionalizing the regulation of AI content and embedding value guidance into the technical system. Creemers (2022) and Nachman, Chen, and Zhao (2022) pointed out that this marks China's transition from the traditional "audit-based" model to a "system-built-in" governance model. The algorithm itself has become part of political control. Under this governance model, control is not only reflected in what content is published but also in the technical design of how to generate, screen, and distribute this content.

The 2017 strategic plan, the 2018 implementation rules, and the 2023 legal system constitute a three-tier framework that jointly regulates how AI participates in the production and management of media content. The first layer sets the main content that the country wants to convey. The second layer provides methods for the specific implementation of these contents within the system. The third layer ensures the implementation of these methods through legal means (Bhatia, 2024; Zhao & Phakdeephirot, 2024). Scholar Zeng (2021) calls this structure a "state-led AI discourse system", emphasizing that this is a highly political technical system. In theory, this system is consistent with the "algorithmic sovereignty" proposed by Mayer-Schönberger and Zeng (2021), that is, the state not only controls the platform and user behavior but also dominates the core values and priorities conveyed by the technology itself.

Many scholars who study the relationship between Chinese politics and technology have pointed out that the impact of AI governance in China goes far beyond the technology itself. Roberts et al. (2020) believe that China's digital systems are used for "responsive repression." These systems enable the government to anticipate public unrest by identifying dissent while they refine their control systems through continuous public feedback analysis. The application of AI extends beyond economic policy enforcement according to Feldstein's (2021) research. It is more like a means of communication, the purpose of which is to align public perception with the political stance of the Communist Party of China. In other words, AI can bring economic growth and strengthen information control. It can help the government monitor, organize, and even suppress possible ideological differences in different media in advance (Jiang et al., 2023; Guo & Feng, 2012; Yang, 2009). Zou and Liu (2024) call this system "automated propaganda infrastructure."

The actual role of AI in communication control is most evident in media programs such as the "AI Gala". Such programs are led by the state and broadcast to a national audience. In these programs, technology is not just a theme, but also a tool for conveying political information. For example, virtual hosts, synthetic voices, and algorithm-generated content have become ways to convey official positions (Levy-Landesberg & Cao, 2024; Hartley, 2024). Such programs are not just entertainment, they are symbolic political rituals. With the help of media ritual theory (Dayan & Katz, 1992) and emotional mobilization research (Yu, 2009; Jiao, 2024), we can see that the state uses these programs to emphasize its legitimacy in technology and values. From this perspective, the "AI Gala" is not only a technological display but also a strategy to consolidate the image of the regime in the form of rituals (Yu, Tay, & Yue, 2023; Ping, 2020).

Overall, through the coordination of policy planning, program production, and strict supervision, China is establishing a unique AI governance model. This model combines cultural traditions, technological development, and political goals to form a new governance tool. This approach is not to reject modern technology but to redefine it so that modernity serves national construction. Through official documents, enforcement mechanisms, and representative activities, the Chinese government portrays AI as an important force for national development and perhaps one of the most effective means of control (Samuel & Asare, 2024; Nachman et al., 2022; Feldstein, 2021).

"Discourse Power" and Ideological Management

In China, the use of digital technology and media platforms to guide public opinion has a long-standing political basis. The CCP attaches great importance to the concept of "discourse power". It refers to who has the right to tell stories, set agendas, and define facts at home and abroad (Pan, 2021; Keane, 2013). The government does not regard new technologies such as AI as neutral tools, but rather as key forces to achieve cultural management and ideological goals (Ping, 2020; Yang & Huang, 2022). In this context, the government not only influences the public through traditional television or radio but also uses algorithms and platform systems to control the dissemination and reception of information (Mayer-Schönberger & Zeng, 2021; Feldstein, 2021; Roberts et al., 2020).

This governance style is not new. Yu (2009) pointed out in his research that the Chinese government has long used large-scale media events such as National Day, the opening ceremony of the Olympic Games, or political anniversaries to unify thoughts. These programs are carefully designed, often using music, images, and collective memories to evoke the audience's emotions and transform political ideas into a shared national experience. Dayan and Katz (1992) called such programs "live broadcasts of history," which not only show the state's position but also create social consensus. Today, this communication method has extended from traditional media to digital space and incorporated AI technology (Zhao, 2008; Yu, 2009; Jiang et al., 2023).

Recently, the government has brought this strategy to smart media, such as the "AI Gala." This state-led event uses AI-generated hosts, cultural images, and government propaganda content to show how state media operates in the digital age (Levy-Landesberg & Cao, 2024). Although these events continue the broadcast tradition of the past, they have added new technologies such as algorithmic recommendations, facial recognition, and synthetic videos (Shi & Zhang, 2024). These technologies not only increase the viewing experience but also make it easier for programs to adapt to different platforms and users, making communication more interactive and influential (Zou & Liu, 2024; Hwang & Huang, 2023).

The government has also institutionalized such communication strategies through policies. The "Guiding Opinions on Promoting the Development of Smart Broadcasting" (2018) clearly proposed to use of AI to improve the ability to guide public opinion and adhere to the correct political direction. This policy emphasizes content security and technical reliability and also positions smart broadcasting as a tool for managing public opinion rather than simply technological progress (NRTA, 2018, p.1). Behind these systems are functions such as real-time monitoring, automatic review, and emotion recognition. AI systems possess the functionality to decide independently what content fulfills political standards while also deciding which content needs removal or transformation (Nachman, Chen, & Zhao, 2022; Franks, Lee, & Xu, 2024). In this framework, AI is not just a tool, but also a mechanism for participating in information screening and amplification (Roberts, 2018; Qiang, 2019).

Therefore, AI has also become an extension of "precision propaganda." It distributes different political information to different groups of people by analyzing audience interests (Samuel & Asare, 2024; Liu, 2024). This is different from traditional indoctrination propaganda, it is more like a "micro-communication". Ideology can be hidden in daily entertainment, life information, and even personalized news (Zeng, 2021; Qiang, 2019). The "AI Gala" is an example of this practice. It packages policy slogans and historical language into part of popular culture, allowing the audience to accept this information unconsciously (Levy-Landesberg & Cao, 2024; Yu, Tay, & Yue, 2023).

The country's emphasis on "positive energy" content is also a reflection of this strategy. This type of content usually emphasizes positivity, unity, technological development, and depoliticized national narratives (Zhao & Phakdeephirot, 2024). In the "AI Gala", the program uses AI to showcase national achievements and moral image, while also serving as a cultural bridge. This propaganda approach is fully in line with the requirements of the "New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan" (2017) and the "Generative Artificial Intelligence Service Measures" (2023), which emphasize that content should spread socialist core values and improve the cultural quality of the public (State Council, 2017; CAC, 2023).

In short, China's current discourse governance approach combines traditional ideological communication with new technological means. Events like the "AI Gala" are typical examples, combining ritual political shows with personalized, algorithm-driven communication methods. This not only improves the propaganda effect but also makes the state's way of controlling information look more modern and more people-friendly (Yu, 2009; Dayan & Katz, 1992; Ping, 2020). This approach foreshadows a new trend in media governance under future authoritarian systems, which will be both symbolic and technically precise with the help ofAI.

AI, Broadcasting, and Cultural Expression

In China, radio has always been an important means for the government to guide public opinion. To understand its role, we must put it in the context of the state's long-term control of media platforms. For many years, television has been the main tool used by the Communist Party of China to release authoritative information and shape political consensus (Zhao, 2008; Shambaugh, 2007). Since the establishment of China Central Television (CCTV), it has been set as the party's voice channel. Even after multiple media reforms and technological updates, this role has not changed (Hong, 2011). In China, television is not only a tool for disseminating information but also an important part of national governance, with the function of strengthening state power and building national identity (Chang & Ren, 2015; Zhang & Wu, 2017).

While digital platforms are developing rapidly, television still has a strong influence in China because of its state-endowed authority, wide coverage, and timely dissemination capabilities. In particular, live broadcasts are more likely to create an atmosphere of authenticity, unity, and urgency (Couldry, 2003; Dayan & Katz, 1992). In China, this media advantage is often reflected in some major festivals and commemorative events, such as the Spring Festival Gala, military parades, or the anniversary of the founding of the party. These programs not only entertain the public but are also used to strengthen political identity and national image (Yu, 2009; Jiao, 2024). They are what Dayan and Katz (1992) call "media events", that is, activities that are carefully designed to break the daily program flow and use them to convey a unified political message. In China, the organization and dissemination of these events are highly controlled by the government, which further reflects the role of the media in the power system (Guo, 2019; Zhang & Wu, 2017).

The "AI Gala" is a continuation of this traditional communication method in the context of contemporary technology. This program, planned by the state broadcaster and broadcast on CCTV, brought AI technology into the framework of mass ritual communication. The choice of television as the main platform is not accidental. It is based on the symbolic role of television in political communication for a long time. Television's authority, mass influence, and close connection with the national image make it an ideal medium for telling stories about technological development and national rejuvenation (Shi & Zhang, 2024; Levy-Landesberg & Cao, 2024). The use of AI virtual hosts and algorithms to produce content in the program combines traditional ritual communication with the new image of technology, shaping AI into a new tool that is trustworthy and in line with national values.

China's use of AI in television shows its broader plan to combine old and new media. The government did not stop using traditional television. Instead, it worked to bring together television, AI, big data, and content recommendation tools (Zhu, 2022; Liu, 2024). This goal is explained in a government document called Guiding Opinions on Promoting the Development of Smart Broadcasting (NRTA, 2018). In China, documents like these are official instructions from government offices. They are not laws, but they are still powerful and often followed closely. This document encourages the use of AI tools like voice recognition, image analysis, and personalized content suggestions in broadcasting. At the same time, it says that all content must follow the right political direction and support socialist values (NRTA, 2018, p.1). So, the goal is not to replace TV with AI. The goal is to use AI to make television more useful for spreading state-approved messages in the digital age.

This approach also reflects the party's emphasis on "cultural confidence." As per Xi Jinping's core proposal, cultural confidence expresses China's cultural worth and soft power (Xi, 2014; Zhao & Phakdeephirot, 2024). The "AI Gala" is a practical platform for this concept. It applies AI to music performances, historical scene restoration, and digital restoration of cultural relics, making technology a tool for inheriting traditional culture (Rui, 2024; Pan, 2021). As some scholars have pointed out, even if the means of communication are constantly changing, China still emphasizes the continuity and symbolic significance of traditional culture in political expression (Ping, 2020; Yu, Tay, & Yue, 2023).

In the program, AI is not only a technical role, but also a cultural expresser. Virtual hosts like "Xiao Xiaoni" speak in nationalist language, quote leaders' speeches, and often have emotional expressions. These designs are not accidental but carefully planned to make AI's performance close to the official position of the government (State Council, 2017; CAC, 2023). The overall style, rhythm, and theme of the program all serve a unified political goal. As Feldstein (2021) said, this is a "consensus" generated by algorithms, that is, to make the automated content consistent with the government's discourse so that the audience can naturally accept it.

In general, the "AI Gala" reflects a new model of political communication in China. This model combines the traditional influence of television, the emotional appeal of ritual activities, and the personalized communication capabilities of AI to create a modern and unified form of cultural expression. Such communication methodology enables domestic political legitimacy formation and simultaneously demonstrates worldwide technological superiority alongside cultural self-confidence (Craig, Lin, & Cunningham, 2021; Samuel & Asare, 2024). Therefore, television is not only not outdated, but has assumed new strategic tasks in this new digital political ecology.

Ethical and Ideological Challenges in AI Governance

As China promotes the development of AI, the ethical issues of AI in media management have attracted increasing attention. People are particularly concerned about its relationship with ideological control, algorithmic responsibility, and social norms. China has not adopted the common AI ethical standards in the West, such as principles centered on individual rights, transparency, and fairness. Instead, China has proposed the concept of "digital civilization" to put AI ethics into a larger political and cultural framework (Keane & Su, 2019; Jiang et al., 2023). The government regards AI as a tool to shape values and public sentiment, not just a technological product (Zeng, 2021; Bhatia, 2024). In this model, AI ethics is not about limiting power, but about strengthening the country's governance capacity (Zhao &

Phakdeephirot, 2024; Levy-Landesberg & Cao, 2024).

At the core of this model is "nudge" - quietly influencing people's views and behaviors through algorithmic design (Keane & Su, 2019). Researchers point out that the Chinese government is increasingly using these technologies to cultivate "ideal citizens" who appear to respect individual choices, but in fact guide people to accept the values set by the state (Cheney-Lippold, 2017; Yang, 2009). In shows like the "AI Gala," AI characters tend to express national pride, promote optimism about technology, and avoid anything sensitive or controversial. These contents seem neutral, but in fact they are reinforcing the "positive energy" narrative (Wang & Liang, 2024; Pan, 2021). Here, the focus of ethics is not to limit the power of technology but to ensure that the dissemination of technology is in line with the value system recognized by the state. Zeng (2022c) calls this practice "the moralization of algorithms."

China's "digital civilization" construction also reflects the government's institutionalized approach to AI ethics. This approach is led by the State Internet Information Office. The "Interim Measures for the Management of Generative Artificial Intelligence Services" issued in 2023 clearly stipulates that it is prohibited to publish content that undermines national authority or disrupts social order (CAC, 2023, Arts. 4 & 7). As per these regulations AI ethical performance must demonstrate robustness in maintaining political stability alongside cultural unity. Some studies believe that this idea originates from traditional Chinese Confucian culture, which emphasizes social harmony and moral education and advocates guiding public opinion through positive content (Fuchs, 2021; Lin & de Kloet, 2020). Therefore, in China, so-called "ethical" AI is actually an extension of state ideology. Jiao (2024) calls this governance style "algorithmic paternalism." In this context, the "AI Gala" has become a stage for displaying state-recognized ethical standards and demonstrating how AI can help spread mainstream values.

In China, talking about AI ethics is often linked to the goals of preventing "cultural pollution" and protecting information sovereignty. Policies such as the "New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan" (State Council, 2017) and the "Guiding Opinions on Promoting the Development of Intelligent Broadcasting and Television" (NRTA, 2018) clearly state that AI should be used to strengthen "correct values" and guide public opinion. Rather than treating AI ethics as a mechanism to protect individual rights, these policies emphasize that it should serve collective identity and core socialist values (Rui, 2024; Shi & Zhang, 2024). AI should not only not produce harmful content, but also actively produce information that meets political requirements. This approach is also supported by empirical research, especially in the regulation of synthetic media (Leibowicz & Cardona, 2024; Samuel & Asare, 2024).

AI is also used in China's political messaging. Concepts like "ethics" are used to help the government keep control. Even when policies talk about "fairness" or "transparency," these ideas are shaped by concerns about national stability and interest. For example, the Interim Measures for the Management of Generative Artificial Intelligence Services (CAC, 2023) is a strict policy from China's main internet office. It says that AI-generated content must support socialist values. It must also avoid harming national unity or public morals. This policy is not just about technology. It builds political control into how AI works. Some researchers call this "discourse governance." This means the government uses rules to keep its power and protect its public image (Creemers, 2022; Roberts, 2018). Views on China's model are mixed. Some see it as a new way to manage AI that fits Chinese society. Others say it weakens global standards for digital rights (Hunter, 2025; Feldstein, 2021).

In actual communication, this governance model also has an impact on public trust. Although China's AI propaganda emphasizes "harmony", if AI is used improperly, it may cause dissatisfaction. Zhao and Phakdeephirot (2024) warned that when crisis strikes populations lack trust in AI systems because of inadequate openness and transparency in accountability systems. Some recent studies have also found that even in a restricted political environment, the Chinese public still hopes that AI systems will be fairer, more inclusive, and more responsive (Nah et al., 2023; Guo & Feng, 2012). This shows that there may be a clear tension between the government's top-down management style and the public's bottom-up moral expectations. Such tension stands out as an essential contradiction in Chinese AI ethical considerations.

Finally, the ethical issues raised by the use ofAI in broadcast media are also related to the future direction of China's technology governance model. While promoting its own AI ethics system at home, China is also promoting its concept of "digital civilization" overseas through infrastructure and soft power (Couldry & Mejias, 2019; Mao & Shi-Kupfer, 2023). The "AI Gala" is not only a local program, but also a window to show China's technological strength and governance concepts to the outside world (Craig, Lin, & Cunningham, 2021; Nachman, Chen, & Zhao, 2022). At a time when global AI ethics are receiving increasing attention, it is still uncertain whether China's model is sustainable. But what is certain is that it has occupied an important position in international AI governance discussions.

Chapter 2 Methodology and Methods

Critical Discourse Analysis

This thesis uses critical discourse analysis (CDA) as a core method to explore how the Chinese government incorporates AI into its media management system through language and narrative. In particular, how the government shapes the public's understanding of AI through television programs such as the "AI Gala". CDA, especially the three-dimensional analysis framework proposed by Fairclough (2010), can study the use of language from three levels: text content, discourse practice, and the social structure behind it. This method helps us understand how the government strengthens its control over media and technology through language (Wang & Lin, 2024; Zhao, 2008; Yu, Tay, & Yue, 2023).

At the text analysis level, CDA pays special attention to word usage and rhetorical strategies. Words such as "strategic technology" and "intelligent broadcasting" are used many times in the "New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan" (State Council, 2017) and the "Guidelines on Intelligent Broadcasting" (NRTA, 2018). These expressions convey a sense of technological optimism and link technological progress with political stability (Pan, 2021; Shi & Zhang, 2024). In terms of discourse practice, this study analyzes how the media spreads policy language by reusing slogans and quoting leaders' speeches. For example, at the "AI Gala", the speech directly quoted Xi Jinping's statement that AI is the "leading goose" (Levy-Landesberg & Cao, 2024; CCTV, 2024). At the social background level, these language strategies are closely related to China's overall digital governance goals, such as strengthening public opinion control, promoting cultural soft power, and enhancing the so-called "discourse power" (Zeng, 2021; Zhao & Phakdeephirot, 2024).

Existing studies have also shown that CDA is very suitable for analyzing China's online communication environment. For example, some people have studied how WeChat and Weibo shaped public opinion during the pandemic, and the language on these platforms is often used to suppress dissent (Zhang et al., 2024; Xu & Flew, 2022). Yu (2009) and Yang (2009) pointed out that China's speech control has extended from traditional media to online platforms, and CDA is an effective way to understand this power structure. Zhang and Negro (2022) also used CDA to study how the state's position is conveyed in live broadcast platforms and AI entertainment content, indicating that the boundary between political propaganda and popular culture is becoming increasingly blurred.

CDA is also widely used in policy text analysis. Studies have found that words such as "security", "modernization" and "digital civilization" are often used to cover up the purpose of technological control (Ding, 2018; Kania, 2020; Zeng, 2021). CDA helps reveal that these seemingly neutral expressions are actually strengthening state intervention (Keane & Su, 2019; Van Noort, 2024; Nachman, Chen, & Zhao, 2022). This study is based on this tradition and analyzes how policy documents and media expressions interact to portray AI as an "efficient", "moral" and "gentle" governance tool.

This thesis further expands the use of CDA and applies it to state-planned media programs such as the "AI Gala". By analyzing this program, we explored how policy language is repackaged and disseminated in television content. To support this research, we used tools such as NVivo to conduct word frequency statistics, topic identification, and sentiment analysis on program texts (Sun, Hu, & Wu, 2022). These technologies help us cross-validate policies, programs, and regulations to build a more comprehensive picture ofAI discourse governance.

In short, CDA is not only used to observe how language reflects policy but also reveals that language itself is a means of governance. It is used to establish legitimacy, mobilize public sentiment, and quietly embed government claims into cultural expressions (Foucault, 1972; Fairclough, 2010; Yu, 2009).

Policy Document Selection

This study focuses on the analysis of three representative AI policy documents. These documents show China's complete path from strategic planning to specific implementation to legal supervision. The "New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan" (2017) is a top-level design at the national level, which outlines a grand blueprint for the development of AI, including development goals, key tasks, and supporting mechanisms (State Council, 2017). Xu and Flew (2022) pointed out that the language of this plan is appealing and reflects the party ' s nationalist expectations for technology (Ding, 2018; Roberts et al., 2020). The "Guiding Opinions on Promoting the Development of Intelligent Broadcasting" (2018) is a mid-level management directive that proposes specific measures for technology integration, content innovation, and talent development for television organizations (Zhao & Liu, 2020). It shows how AI is gradually being integrated into the propaganda system (Shi & Zhang, 2024; Zhao & Phakdeephirot, 2024). The "Interim Measures for the Management of Generative Artificial Intelligence Services" issued in 2023 is a manifestation of the regulatory level. This legal document sets out the norms that AI platforms must follow and restricts content that poses a risk to national stability (CAC, 2023; Creemers, 2023).

By analyzing these three documents together, we can see the hierarchical structure of China ' s policy language. Scholars point out that this stratification is critical to understanding how the Chinese government has advanced policy control over time (Zeng, 2021; Zhu & Zhong, 2024). Chen and Wang (2022) also emphasize that policy documents are not only management tools, but also part of ideological communication.

These documents show that the party not only regards AI as a means of economic development but also as a tool for political propaganda (Rui, 2024; Ping, 2020).

Media Text Selection — AI Gala

To supplement the analysis of policy texts, we also analyzed the program "AI Gala". The reason for choosing it is that it not only embodies the core concept of the national AI strategy but also represents the application scenario of AI in China at the cultural level. The program is broadcast by CCTV, covering the whole country, and has a high degree ofpolitical and media representativeness (Levy-Landesberg & Cao, 2024). We used speech-to-text tools to obtain the entire content of the program and proofread it one by one to ensure the accuracy of the data. This process conforms to the conventional operating standards of critical media research (Cottle, 2006; Zhang & Wu, 2017).

Image 2.1 Screenshot of the Speech-to-Text Transcript from the AI Gala, Created Using iFlytek

This image shows a transcript with time stamps from the 2024 AI Gala. The transcript was made using iFlytek[2], a speech recognition tool often used in China. It covers over 66 minutes of the broadcast. It helped pick out key moments where the program repeated messages that matched government goals. These moments often focused on three main themes: new technology, cultural pride, and digital control. The language used in the transcript reflects a pattern where the state carefully shapes public messages. This matches what Roberts (2018) calls "authoritarian deliberation." It

[2] iFlytekis a Chinese speech recognition platform used in this study for transcribing audiovisual content from national media programs. For more information, visit https://www.iflytek.com/en/

means the government allows some public discussion, but only inside a controlled media space.

We recorded the dialogues, narrations, scripts, and performances in the programs sentence by sentence, and marked the specific time points (such as "03:36") for subsequent analysis. As Dayan and Katz (1992) said, this type of program is a "national ritual" that conveys political ideas through vision and sound. The AI Gala also inherited this tradition, integrating the country's technological confidence and cultural sentiment into a unified communication narrative (Yu, 2009; Jiao, 2024). For example, the program directly recited Xi Jinping's speech on AI, placing entertainment content under the discourse of power, which is also common in other national media activities led by other countries (Pan, 2021; Ping, 2020).

Based on the changes in the program's images and narrative logic, we classified the program content by theme. For example, some segments focused on the application of AI in agriculture and education, while others showed traditional culture through virtual characters. This classification helped us match policy goals with program content one by one and make detailed comparisons (Jiang, Lan, Wang, & Zhang, 2023). This approach allows us to establish a clear link between macro-policy and micro-media, an approach that has been recognized in political communication and algorithmic media research (Roberts et al., 2020; Guo & Feng, 2012).

Coding and Thematic Analysis

This thesis adopts a mixed research method, combining qualitative coding and quantitative text analysis, and uses NVivo software for collation and analysis. The study is based on the critical discourse analysis (CDA) proposed by Fairclough (2010). CDA emphasizes that language choices and expressions often reflect larger social and political structures. The first step of this study is to conduct a keyword frequency analysis to find the most used core words in the three policy documents and the text records of the "AI Gala", such as "AI", "development", "technology" and "regulation". We also analyzed the co-occurrence of these keywords in paragraphs to reveal the order of expression emphasis in different texts. This method refers to the corpus-assisted CDA research standards (Baker et al., 2008; Flowerdew & Richardson, 2017).

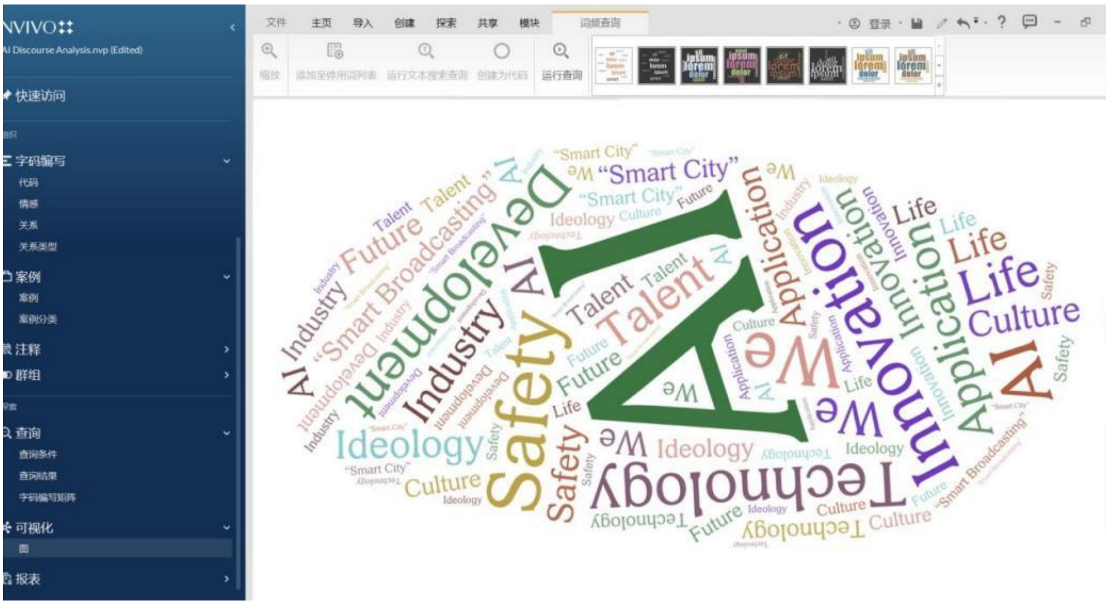


Image 2.2 Word Cloud Created in NVivo Shows the Most Common Terms in the Dataset

This word cloud was made using NVivo[3]. The data came from official policy papers and media texts listed in Table 1. Words like "development," "technology," "innovation," and "culture" appeared most often. These words show that government policies and media stories use the same terms. They support the same ideas. Yu and Liu (2024) describe this pattern as a "strategic narrative regime." This means the government repeats certain ideas to guide how people think about digital change. The word choices help link cultural symbols with political goals. This supports a system where the government uses digital media to strengthen its control (Creemers, 2020; Zeng, 2022).

The quantitative analysis results show that China's AI policy has changed over time. Policies in 2017 and 2018 focused on new technology and business growth. By 2023, the focus had shifted to safety, control, and political values. This supports earlier research by Zeng, Chan, and Schäfer (2020) and Nachman, Chen, and Zhao (2022). These scholars say China's AI governance has moved from growth-based to control-based. The early stage aimed to boost innovation and industry. The newer stage puts more weight on regulation, risk control, and political guidance. These changes are backed by data and support a deeper analysis of how China uses AI rules. The findings also match ideas from Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA), which combines theory with close empirical evidence (Wodak & Meyer, 2015).

On this basis, the study further established a hierarchical coding system, from major categories to subcategories, and then to specific indicators and examples, clearly dividing four main themes: (a) national technological development, (b) cultural propaganda, (c) governance and control, and (d) AI ethics and optimism. These

[3] NVivo is a qualitative analysis software used to code, visualize, and thematically analyze both policy texts and media scripts. For more information, visit https://www.qsrinternational.com/nvivo

themes are specifically disassembled in the text. For example, in the "Governance and Control" section, subcategories include monitoring mechanisms, national supervision, and regulatory enforcement, echoing the classification of Creemers (2023) and Roberts (2018). In the "Cultural Propaganda" section, we marked the content related to cultural confidence, traditional values, identity expression, etc., which is consistent with Zhao (2008) and Yu (2009)'s views on media rituals and cultural construction.

We used NVivo to build clear links between what the text says and the topics we studied. We also used cross-tabulation to compare how different people — like government officials, media workers, business leaders, and experts—talked about AI. This method helps us see how each group focuses on different points. It follows the idea of "layered narrative analysis" from Feldstein (2021), which looks at how different voices shape a message. We also checked our understanding by looking at keyword pairings. For example, we looked at how often words like "AI + empowerment" or "AI + governance" appeared together. This follows the method suggested by Guo and Feng (2012). They say it is important to find repeated patterns in how people talk about politics in China. In many cases, words and roles in these messages are not random. They are carefully planned. Our results match their idea that Chinese media often repeats the same message structure. These structures link government goals, speaker identity, and topic choices. Together, they help create a unified political message.

Overall, this thesis established a clear and replicable method system, combining quantitative text processing and interpretive coding, to help us track the continuity of power structures and strategic changes in China's AI discourse. The "AI Gala" is not only a cultural program, but can also be understood as a specific example of the government manipulating discourse in the media, promoting the legitimization of technology, and spreading governance concepts.

Chapter 3 Policy Infrastructure and Narrative Power: Governing AI through Discourse and Media Architecture

Artificial intelligence (AI) plays an important role in China's national growth plan. It is seen not just as a tool for technology but also as a way to spread state ideas. This chapter looks at how AI is used in media control. It focuses on three main government documents. These are the New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan (State Council, 2017), the Guidance on Promoting the Development of Smart Broadcasting (NRTA, 2018), and the Interim Measures for the Management of Generative Artificial Intelligence Services (CAC, 2023). These policies work together to build a system where AI is part of media operations. AI is not only used to make work faster or more organized. It is also used to shape messages and keep them in line with official views (Creemers, 2020; Zeng, 2021). This system combines technology with politics. It uses AI to manage how stories are told and how values are shared. The idea behind this is often called "discourse governance." This means the state tries to manage public talk and information. The chapter explains how this idea shows up in media rules and in public events. One example is the AI Gala. This event puts the state's policies on display in a way that feels entertaining. It also helps support the state's image and authority (Yu, Tay, & Yue, 2023; Pan, 2021).

Embedding AI in Media Policy Infrastructure

The Chinese government sees AI as a key force in promoting national development and also believes that it can help strengthen the management of the media and cultural sectors. In the "New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan" released in 2017, the government defined AI as a core technology that "leads the future" and emphasized that it will drive economic growth, social modernization, and national security (State Council, 2017, p. 1). This positioning reflects China's high attention to technology in recent years and also reflects the thinking of "technological nationalism", that is, to enhance national strength through independent research and development of technology (Zeng, Chan, & Schäfer, 2020; Zhao, 2008; Roberts, 2018). The plan sets the goal of becoming a global leader in AI by 2030 while emphasizing the need to master key core technologies and strengthen the management of data and networks to ensure the so-called "cyber sovereignty" (State Council, 2017, p. 1; Creemers, 2022; Zeng, 2022b). In this general framework, AI will not only be used in industries or medical fields, but will also be deeply involved in the media system to improve efficiency, maintain stability, and unify thoughts (Wang & Lin, 2024; Levy-Landesberg & Cao, 2024).

The plan also places special emphasis on the role of the media. The government requires propaganda agencies to make full use of traditional and new media to report the latest progress in AI in a timely manner and strive to create an atmosphere of "universal support for technological development" (State Council, 2017, p. 32). This approach reflects the CCP's consistent strategy of using propaganda to build consensus during periods of rapid change (Zhao, 2008; Guo & Feng, 2012). The policy requires technology to be "safe, controllable, and reliable" and ultimately serve the overall goals of the socialist system (Roberts et al., 2020; Samuel & Asare, 2024; Bhatia, 2024). Therefore, media propaganda on AI is not only a popular science act but also a political means to shape technological development into a common cause recognized by the state and accepted by the public (Yu, Tay, & Yue, 2023; Pan, 2021).

Driven by this national vision, the State Administration of Radio and Television issued the "Guiding Opinions on Promoting the Development of Smart Broadcasting" in 2018, which made specific arrangements for the reform of the radio and television sector. The document put forward the concept of "smart broadcasting", which means combining technologies such as AI and big data with media production processes to improve broadcasting efficiency and audience experience while ensuring that political positions do not deviate (NRTA, 2018, p. 1). The policy also requires the radio and television system to connect with the strategic directions of "Digital China" and "Digital Economy" proposed by the state to ensure that the broadcasting industry remains technologically advanced (Shi & Zhang, 2024; Liu, 2024; Hong & Wei, 2022). However, all these technological upgrades must be carried out under ideological control. The policy clearly states that broadcasting organizations must assume "ideological work responsibilities" and always adhere to the party’s lines and principles (NRTA, 2018, p. 1). This also shows that China does not intend to let technological development weaken the government's control but to use new technologies to further consolidate this control (Jiang, Lan, Wang, & Zhang, 2023; Zhao & Phakdeephirot, 2024).

The 2018 policy is actually a specific implementation of the 2017 overall strategy in the media field. The document requires the use of AI technology to create "main melody" content and spread "positive energy", that is, to let these programs help guide the public's values and emotions in the direction desired by the party (NRTA, 2018, p. 2). This is what some researchers call "automated propaganda" - automatically generating content through technical means while amplifying traditional propaganda functions (Roberts et al., 2020; Nachman, Chen, & Zhao, 2022). Therefore, from the perspective of "smart broadcasting", the digital transformation of the broadcasting industry is not just a technological update, but also a political continuation.

The latest progress in this development path is the "Interim Measures for the Management of Generative Artificial Intelligence Services" issued in 2023. This document was issued by the Cyberspace Administration of China and mainly formulates legal provisions for AI-generated content. It explicitly requires that all AI-generated content must comply with the "core socialist values" and prohibits the publication of content that may "disrupt social order" or "undermine national unity" (CAC, 2023, Articles 4, 5). As Creemers (2022) puts it, this is a manifestation of "anticipatory algorithmic governance", that is, rather than reviewing content after it is released, restrictions are set at every stage from data training to content output (Creemers, 2016; Samuel & Asare, 2024). In addition, this policy reiterates the "safe, reliable, and controllable" principles proposed in 2017, emphasizing that AI cannot be out of government control (CAC, 2023; State Council, 20177).

These three policy documents show China 's governance path for AI: the 2017 plan proposed a long-term strategy, the 2018 broadcasting guidelines were implemented in the media industry, and the 2023 AI content management measures went further into technical details. This whole arrangement embodies what Mayer-Schönberger and Zeng (2021) call "algorithmic sovereignty"—the state not only controls technology platforms and data but also determines how AI should "think" and "express." In China, this means that AI systems must not only function properly but also be consistent with the party's ideology (Ping, 2020; Franks, Lee, & Xu, 2024).

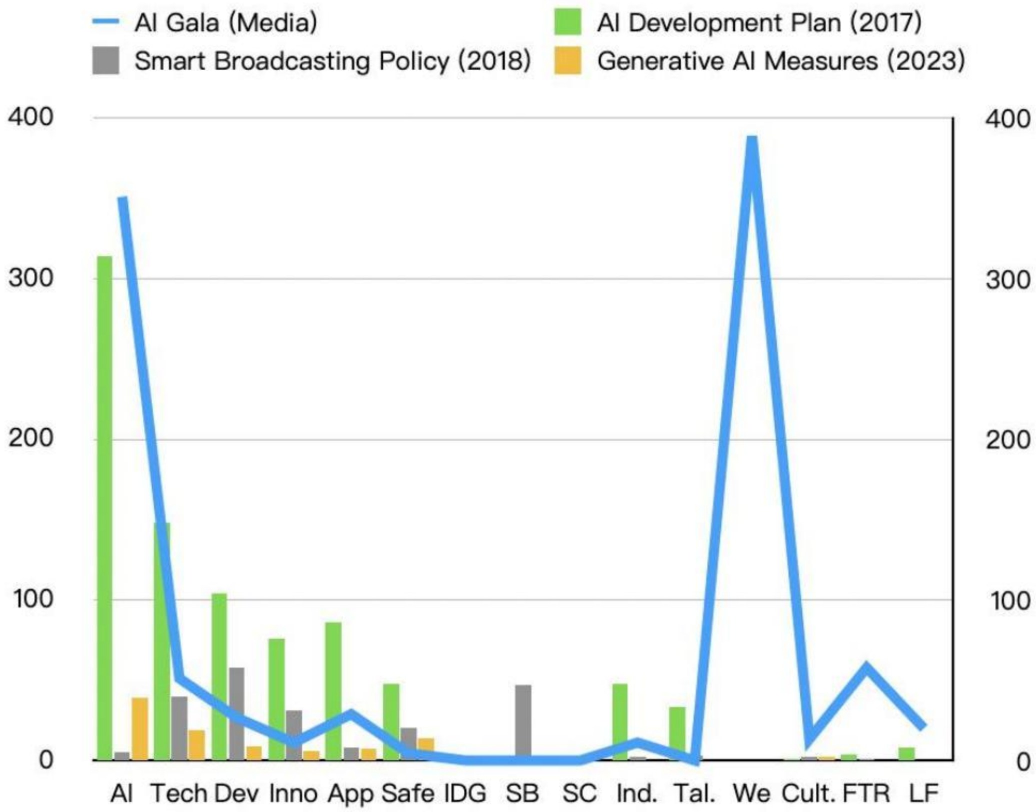


Image 3.1 Keyword Frequency Comparison across Policy Documents and the AI Gala Transcript

This image compares how often certain keywords appear in four texts. These include the New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan (2017), the Guidance on Promoting the Development of Smart Broadcasting (2018), the Interim Measures for the Management of Generative Artificial Intelligence Services (2023), and the transcript from the 2024 AI Gala. The keyword data comes from coding results listed in Table 1 in the appendix.

The chart shows that all four texts use words like "AI," "technology," "development," and "innovation" many times. These words create a shared message. Both the government documents and the Gala speak about AI in ways that show hope and belief in progress (Cave & Dihal, 2019; Zeng, 2022). At the same time, there are clear differences. The 2023 policy on generative AI often uses words like "safety" and "ideology." These words show that the document is focused on control and risk. The text works as a rulebook for how AI should be used.

The AI Gala, on the other hand, rarely uses those words. It focuses more on terms like "talent," "culture," and "future." These words speak to feelings, dreams, and national pride. The show uses these terms to create a story about AI that feels inspiring and hopeful. This contrast shows two different styles. Policy texts stress control and safety. The Gala chooses to highlight emotions and shared identity. It presents AI as something that brings pride and shows progress (Levy-Landesberg & Cao, 2024; Yu, Tay, & Yue, 2023; Shi & Zhang, 2024).

Compared with policy language, emotional words such as "future" and "hope" appeared more frequently in the manuscripts of the ceremony. These terms make AI look like not just technology, but a symbol of ideals and visions (Yu, 2009; Couldry, 2003). From a rhetorical perspective, media content turns the originally abstract policy language into a narrative that can stimulate the public's imagination in a more attractive way. Programs like the AI Gala are a form of cultural propaganda. It packages regulatory ideas into a positive story of national development, giving it a more intimate and humane image.

In summary, whether in policy documents or media programs, China's AI discourse conveys a unified message: AI is not only the direction of technological innovation but also an important part of national governance. This discourse system gives AI a dual identity-it is both a practical tool and a symbolic national project. This combination enables AI to play a key role in China’s digital political ecology, driving a state-defined and state-controlled innovation path (Feldstein, 2021; Zhang, 2023).

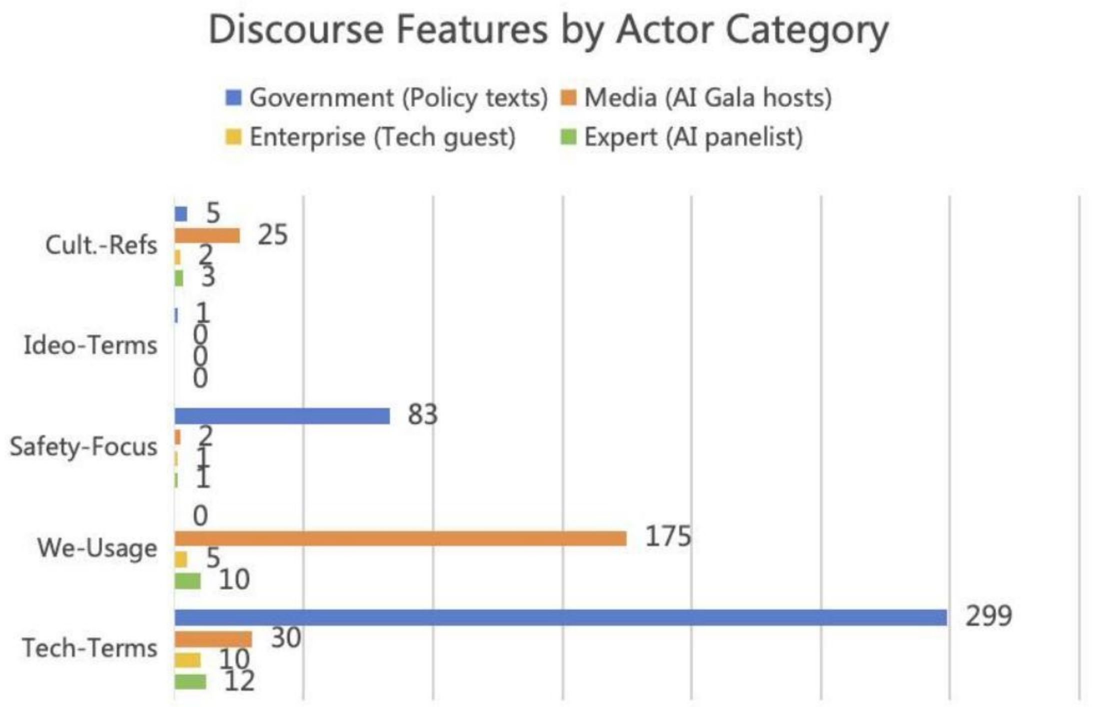
From Discourse Power to Performative Ideology

China’s push for AI in the media sector is not just about improving its technological capabilities, but also about strengthening its "discourse power"—the ability of the state to control public opinion and guide thought (Brady, 2008; Pan, 2021). This means of control is particularly important as digital technology increasingly influences society (Keane & Su, 2019; Zhu & Fu, 2024). For example, the 2017 "AI Development Plan" and the 2018 "Guidance on Intelligent Broadcasting" clearly state that the development of AI must serve national governance and core socialist values (State Council, 2017, p. 32; NRTA, 2018, p. 1). These policies directly incorporate the Party’s guiding role into the basic framework of technology application, continuing China’s long-standing practice of ideological management through traditional and digital media (Zhao, 2008; Yu, 2009). The document proposes to "do a good job in guiding public opinion," indicating that the government is trying to maintain the stability of the propaganda system while updating technology.

The "AI Gala" is a typical manifestation of this strategy. This is a state-led media event jointly launched by CCTV and the Central Cyberspace Administration of China, with the goal of presenting AI policy to the public in a more understandable and attractive way (Jiang et al., 2023). The program opened with a quote from Xi Jinping’s speech on AI as a "strategic technology" and mentioned the "leader effect", emphasizing that the leadership hopes that China will become a global benchmark in this field (CCTV, 2024, 03:00; Ping, 2020). This approach is consistent with the strategy of Chinese official media: to strengthen the legitimacy and unity of policy by repeatedly quoting high-level speeches (Shambaugh, 2007; Levy-Landesberg & Cao, 2024).

Image 3.2 Speaker Hierarchy and Symbolic Authority Figures in the AI Gala

But in addition to the quotes, the design of the program itself is also deeply influenced by ideology. Fairclough (2010) pointed out that media content distributes power by arranging who speaks, what they say, and how they say it. In Chinese media, this arrangement is particularly strict, especially in major programs (Nguyen & Hekman, 2022). In the AI Gala, the hosts, experts, and guests expressed a consistent national narrative through a unified discourse style (Image 3.2 above). This setting is consistent with Zhao’s (2008) description of Chinese television: clear hierarchy and clear propaganda orientation. The analysis of discourse features shown in Appendix Table 2 suggests that participants in the AI Gala—especially state-related figures—operated within an overarching ideological framework that reaffirms the party-state's position as the main narrator of technological progress (Guo & Feng, 2012; Pan, 2021).



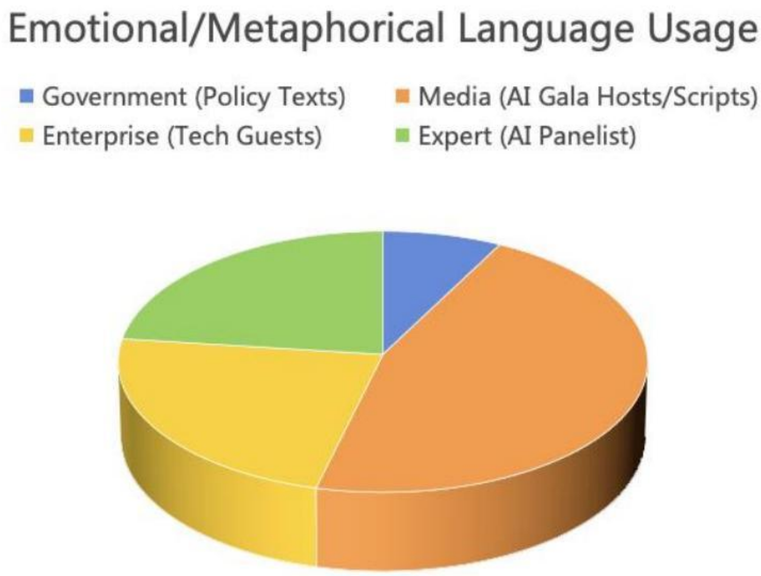


Image 3.3 Discourse Styles by Actor Type and Emotional Language Use

The bar chart compares five types of language. These are technical terms, safety or control references, ideological words, cultural mentions, and the use of the word "we." The chart shows how these appear across four groups: government (policy documents), media (AI Gala hosts), business (tech guests), and experts (panelists). The pie chart shows how much each group uses emotional or metaphorical language.

This data comes from manual coding of the texts listed in Appendix Table 2.

The pie chart shows that media and business speakers use more emotional and symbolic language. Government sources use fewer of these expressions. Government texts stay formal. They rely on facts, rules, and technical descriptions. This shows that each group has a different way of speaking. Each group also serves a different role in how China talks about AI. Government documents focus on facts and regulations. The texts include 299 uses of technical words and 83 mentions of safety or control (State Council, 2017, p. 2; CAC, 2023, pp. 4–6). These numbers show that the government sees AI as something that must be closely managed. It presents AI as a national system that needs planning and oversight (Wang & Lin, 2024; Zeng, Chan, & Schäfer, 2020). Words like "talent," "governance," and "security" appear often. These terms show themes like national goals, risk management, and state duty.

By contrast, the AI Gala uses a different tone. It focuses more on emotion and inclusion. The word "we" appears 175 times in the show. It does not appear in any of the government texts. This word helps create a sense of unity and shared purpose (Azahra & Suhaimi, 2024). The Gala uses friendly and emotional language instead of official or top-down speech. This shift shows a new way of spreading state messages that feel more open and people-focused (Creemers, 2020; Yang & Huang, 2022).

The way the Gala handles political ideas is also different. The word "ideology" appears in the 2018 Smart Broadcasting guidance (NRTA, 2018, p. 3). It does not appear in the Gala script. This suggests that political messages are now hidden in stories and emotions instead of direct statements (Zhao & Phakdeephirot, 2024; Sun, Hu, & Wu, 2022). The word "safety" appears 83 times in policy documents. In the Gala, it appears only twice (CCTV, 2024, 00:37:20). The show uses a positive and hopeful tone. This shows how official ideas about control are replaced by cheerful stories in public media (Keane & Su, 2019).

Chapter 4 Spectacle, Emotion, and Authority: Performing AI Nationhood in Chinese State Broadcasting

The Chinese government has a long history of using media events to promote its ideas (Zhao, 2008; Keane & Su, 2019). This chapter looks at how the AI Gala follows that pattern. It shows how new technologies like algorithms are added to traditional media shows. These tools help reshape how political messages are delivered to the public. The AI Gala presents technology not just as progress. It also shows it as part of China's cultural and moral values. The show connects high-tech images with the idea of "cultural confidence" (Shi & Zhang, 2024; Wang & Lin, 2024). This means the state wants people to feel proud of Chinese culture while also accepting new technologies. This chapter explains how shows like the AI Gala turn complex government goals into simple and emotional stories. These stories are easy for the audience to understand. They use fun formats like songs, dances, and light jokes. These performances make policies feel more friendly. At the same time, they still carry strong political messages (Feldstein, 2021; Cave & Dihal, 2019).

Cultural Nationalism Through AI Spectacle

Although the Chinese government has always played a leading role in information dissemination, the AI Gala showed another way to promote technology through cultural expression and storytelling. The gala is not only a scientific and technological event to showcase AI, but also a program that combines entertainment, technology, and emotion. It puts AI into a familiar cultural context, making it easier for the audience to understand and accept (Zhao & Phakdeephirot, 2024; Levy-Landesberg & Cao, 2024). The program does not treat AI as a cold and abstract technology but portrays it as part of the Chinese story and a hopeful partner in people's lives. This approach continues the consistent style of China's mainstream media - packaging technology as a symbol of the country's future and giving it positive emotions and national significance (Zeng, Chan, & Schäfer, 2020; Pan, 2021).

One prominent example is the integration of AI and traditional culture. In one segment, the program used virtual reality technology to "revive" the Terracotta Warriors (Image 4.1 below). The host said in a tone full of surprise: "Now the Terracotta Warriors are no longer just exhibits behind glass - wearing a VR helmet, everyone can get close to it and feel the momentum of the Qin Dynasty." (CCTV, 2024, 15:07) This segment reflects the country's desire to "activate" cultural heritage through digital means, that is, to use technology to make traditional culture tangible and perceptible (State Council, 2017; CAC, 2023). In this segment, the program also added Shaanxi dialect rap, telling historical stories in the local language, and combining AI with local culture. This design method not only showcases technology but also evokes people's emotional resonance with history and homeland (Zeng, 2022a; Rui, 2024; Liu, 2024).

Image 4.1 AI Integration with Heritage: Terracotta Warriors and Wing Chun Performance

There was also a segment about Wing Chun, a traditional Chinese martial art (Image 4.1 above). This style is known for its short-distance fighting and strong cultural meaning. The host asked, "What will happen if Wing Chun meets AI?" (CCTV, 2024, 24:35). After that, the show presented how AI tools could support martial arts training. This brought together old skills and new tools. Scholars like Yu (2009) and Keane and Su (2019) believe this is not by chance. They say the state uses this kind of message on purpose. The goal is to show that AI can help Chinese culture instead of just being seen as a Western idea (Shi & Zhang, 2024; Zhu, 2022). The show uses this to promote what the state calls "cultural confidence." This means keeping national culture strong while using new technology (Zhao, 2008; Wang & Lin, 2024).

Another part of the program showed how AI helps farmers. The host took viewers to a village in Xinjiang. There, AI tools like drones and spraying machines are used in farming (CCTV, 2024, 23:09). This fits with the "AI and agriculture" goal that was part of a 2017 national policy. It also supports the country's larger plan to improve rural life (State Council, 2017; CAC, 2023; Yang & Huang, 2022). By showing AI in farming, the show made the technology feel useful and close to everyday life. It made clear that AI is not just about big national projects. It also helps small communities. This use of AI also builds what the state sees as cultural "authenticity." When AI tools are used in traditional farming, they seem more local and less foreign. This makes AI look like it fits naturally into Chinese life. In this story, AI is not an outsider. It becomes a helper that works with older ways of living. This supports the government's role in using technology to shape modern life through culture (Guo & Feng, 2012; Yu, 2009; Zhu & Fu, 2024). Couldry and Mejias (2019) call this a kind of "data colonialism" with local features. They say digital power grows not only by control but also by becoming part of cultural life.

One part of the program shows how AI service robots help people with work and daily tasks. The host calls these robots "helpers" and "partners" (CCTV, 2024, 00:22). This choice of words presents AI as a tool that supports people, not as something that might take over. The program follows the official view that people and machines should work together. It avoids the idea of conflict between humans and AI. This message helps reduce public worry about AI replacing human skills (Leibowicz & Cardona, 2024; Bhatia, 2024). The tone of the program is also relaxed. The host makes light jokes about an AI version of himself. He says, "I have to wait until the 2.0 version of the high emotional intelligence and high IQ clone comes out before considering letting it play" (CCTV, 2024, 03:00). These kinds of jokes make AI seem friendly and easy to relate to. They help viewers feel more comfortable with the idea of AI in daily life. AI is shown as something that is fun, safe, and not too serious (Azahra & Suhaimi, 2024; Samuel & Asare, 2024).

These contents show how the program uses narrative and emotional techniques to convey policy information. This narrative style is in sharp contrast to the language style of policy documents. According to the statistics in Appendix Table 3, in policy texts, AI is most often paired with words such as "technology" and "development", while in the ceremony, it is more associated with "future" and "life" (Wang, 2022; Nachman, Chen, & Zhao, 2022). This shows that policy documents emphasize national-level strategies, while programs focus more on public acceptance.

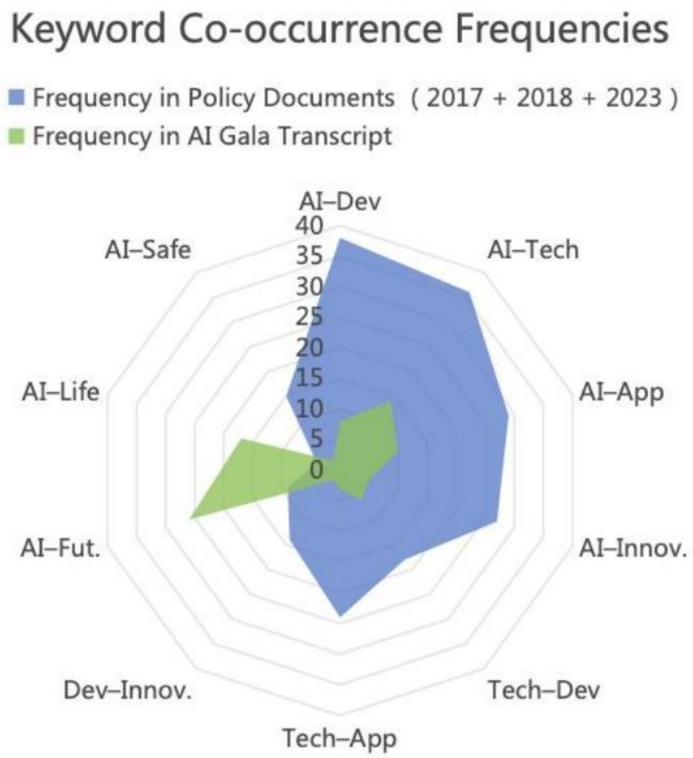


Image 4.2 Co-Occurrence of "AI" with Key Themes in Policy Texts and the AI Gala Transcript

This chart shows how often the word "AI" appears with other important words. It compares three national policy documents from 2017 to 2023 with the transcript from the 2024 AI Gala. The data comes from coding results listed in Appendix Table 3.

In policy documents, the most common word pairings include "AI and development," "AI and technology," and "AI and application." These combinations appear often. They show how the government talks about AI in terms of planning, progress, and global strength (Ding, 2018; Zeng, 2022). These terms support the idea that AI is a tool for national goals. The state sees AI as something to be used in large systems and for long-term strategies. These words reflect that the government regards AI as an important tool to promote modernization and enhance national competitiveness, emphasizing efficiency, industrial upgrading, and technological breakthroughs (Vykhodets, 2022; Pan, 2021).

The AI Gala uses a different style. It still shows some technical terms, such as "AI and technology" (14 times), but it also includes more emotional pairings. For example, "AI and the future" appears 26 times, and "AI and life" appears 17 times. These words are used less in the policy documents. They show a shift in focus. The media tries to make AI feel closer to personal experience. It presents AI as part of daily life and as something that can bring hope (Franks, Lee, & Xu, 2024; Jiang, Lan, Wang, & Zhang, 2023). The AI Gala shows AI helping real people in different settings. These include farming, health care, and home life. In one part of the program, a host says, "AI helps agriculture take off" (CCTV, 2024, 00:44:12). This phrase uses a metaphor to create emotion. It makes people feel connected to the idea of AI, even if the message is not very technical.

Besides, policy documents often also talk about AI with a focus on safety. The phrase "AI and safety" appears 15 times in rules and plans. In the AI Gala, this phrase is used only twice. It is not part of a larger policy context (CCTV, 2024, 00:07:35; CAC, 2023; State Council, 2017). This shows a clear change in tone. Government texts focus on control and structure. The media shows AI as something to celebrate. This change in how words are used suggests that different types of texts serve different goals. Policy texts explain rules. Media programs create feelings. Each version helps the state communicate its vision in different ways (Feldstein, 2021; Roberts, 2018).

At the same time, the program does not use political words like "ideology" when talking about AI. This does not mean politics is missing. Instead, it shows that political ideas are being shared in quieter ways. The program uses feelings and culture to deliver values without stating them directly (Ping, 2020; Yu, Tay, & Yue, 2023). This style matches what Keane and Su (2019) call "soft ideological packaging." Official documents often focus less on emotion and culture. However, the AI Gala uses music, symbols, and stories to create a national feeling (Image 4.3). It includes things like calligraphy and folk songs to make AI seem part of traditional Chinese culture. This creates a warm and festive mood. It connects technology with national pride and shared values (Rui, 2024; Shi & Zhang, 2024). These details help the message feel natural. It does not feel like a lecture. It feels like a celebration.

Image 4.3 Aestheticized AI Narratives Through Music and Symbols

In summary, the AI Gala reflects an important strategy of the country in media governance: it not only conveys policy content but also guides the public's understanding and imagination ofAI through emotional and cultural expressions. This "soft packaging" not only gives technology functional significance but also brings emotional warmth and cultural identity (Craig, Lin, & Cunningham, 2021; Sun, Hu, & Wu, 2022). In this way, radio and television have become an important stage for shaping public sentiment and national science and technology vision.

Controlling AI Ethics: National Sovereignty and Narrative Security

Although the AI Gala conveyed an optimistic narrative about technological progress and social harmony, the process of AI entering China's media and governance system also exposed many ethical and ideological tensions. The gala itself reflects a basic contradiction: how to balance the technological advantages of automation with the dominance of humans. On the one hand, the program portrays AI as a collaborative and trustworthy partner through the cooperation of real hosts and virtual images; on the other hand, it also reveals the hidden concerns about technology replacing human roles. In a lighthearted segment of the program, the host joked that maybe one day he would be replaced by an AI version with high emotional intelligence (CCTV, 2024, 03:00). Although this joke is light, it actually reflects the public's potential anxiety about the threat of automation to employment. Research also points out that this anxiety, relieved by humor, precisely reflects people's doubts about AI's involvement in the field of creativity or public expression (Dignum, 2019; Soeffner, 2025).

The program presents AI as both a helper and a possible rival to humans. This shows how the state views AI. It supports the growth of AI but also stays alert to its risks. One main concern is how people talk about AI and who controls that conversation. Government policies clearly state that AI must stay under human control. This phrase appears often in important documents like the 2017 national AI plan and the 2018 broadcasting guidelines (State Council, 2017, p.2; NRTA, 2018, p.1). The goal is to make sure AI does not grow in ways that weaken the Party's role in shaping society and public opinion. When new technology brings uncertainty, governments often react by tightening control. Birtchnell and Urry (2015) explain that such moments usually lead to stronger human-centered rules. In China, this takes the form of "discourse control." This means the state works to guide how AI is talked about and understood. It sets the limits on what people can say about AI. It also shapes how AI should be used. This helps the state keep its authority over both technology and public messaging (Creemers, 2020; Zou & Liu, 2024).

Another prominent issue is the conflict between the content generation capabilities of generative AI and the consistency of national ideology. Although the ceremony showcased many amazing scenes of AI technology, it clearly avoided topics such as algorithmic bias, deepfakes, and false information that are widely discussed internationally (Floridi et al., 2018; Crawford, 2021). This is not just a matter of choosing an angle but also reflects that in an authoritarian system, if the content generation capabilities are not regulated, they may produce content that challenges the government's discourse and threatens the legitimacy of the country (Roberts, 2018; Hunter, 2025).

In response, the Chinese government has begun to adopt a clearer response strategy. The "Administrative Measures for Generative Artificial Intelligence Services" issued in 2023 established a mandatory value framework. The document clearly requires that all AI-generated content must "reflect the core socialist values" and must not contain any content that may threaten national unity or spread violence, discrimination, or false information (CAC, 2023, Art. 4, Sec.1). This is exactly what Muldoon and Wu (2023) call "algorithmic sovereignty" - the government must not only manage platforms, data, and users but also directly intervene in the output of AI. The regulations also set out clear requirements for technology companies, such as protecting privacy, strengthening transparency, and labeling generated content (CAC, 2023, Art. 12), further illustrating the government's desire to integrate ethical standards and political control (Zeng & Cheng, 2023).

This type of control suggests that in China, AI content output, like traditional media, must comply with official ideological boundaries. This control is not only reflected in policies but also extends to the system architecture itself. Developers need to preset filtering mechanisms in AI models to ensure that the content it generates is "compliant and controllable" (Chen, 2023; Vykhodets, 2022). The document also stipulates ethical responsibilities, such as preventing minors from becoming addicted, guiding users to use it reasonably, and setting up reporting mechanisms to combat false information (Xiao, He, & Ge, 2024). As Chen, Lu, and Wu (2023) point out, this approach represents a unique Chinese "digital norm", where technology is not just a tool but also a channel to achieve political goals.

Therefore, China ’s AI governance logic is clearly different from the Western model centered on individual rights. China's governance model is more collectivist, emphasizing social stability, cultural unity, and political control (Zhao & Phakdeephirot, 2024; Ping, 2020). For example, while Western society widely discusses "how AI impacts employment", Chinese media emphasizes "AI brings retraining opportunities" and incorporates such transformations into state-led education or career policies (Leung, 2021; Pan, 2021). Similarly, discussions about algorithmic discrimination have been redefined as "technical issues" that should be solved through centralized management rather than triggering public debate or protests (Guo & Feng, 2012; Yang, 2009). Judging from these expressions, China's AI ethics system emphasizes "harmony" rather than "confrontation", which is influenced by both Confucian traditions and the continuation of modern authoritarian governance (Wang & Lin, 2024; Samuel & Asare, 2024).

This idea has also continued in China's international statements on AI. At the "Winning in AI+" forum held in 2025, many scientists and policy officials proposed that "development and security" and "openness and control" are the focus of future work. An official expert said that China hopes to build an AI system that is "technical, warm and ethical" (CCTV, 2025). This sentence conveys not only a technological vision, but also expresses the logic of governance: technology can be strong, but it must operate under the management of the party (Bhatia, 2024; Rostamian & Kamreh, 2024). This statement also appeared at the end of the AI Gala. The host said, "The stage for innovation belongs to everyone" and invited the public to participate in the development of AI in the future - but this participation is carried out within the value framework and regulatory track set by the state (CCTV, 2024, 01:05:08).

Overall, the Chinese government is pushing for the growth of AI. At the same time, it is making sure that AI does not challenge political power or social order. This approach mixes new technology with tight control. AI is used both to modernize the country and to spread political ideas (Cave & Dihal, 2019; Feldstein, 2021). The government uses laws, media stories, and rules to shape how people think about AI. It wants to build a tech culture that fits with the Party ’s ideas. In this culture, AI stands for national pride. It also must be safe and follow official values (Nachman, Chen, & Zhao, 2022). It is hard to say if this model will work well in the future. What is clear is that in China, AI is not just about machines or software. It is tied to political control, media limits, and how the state tells its story (Creemers, 2020; Zeng, 2021; Sun, Hu, & Wu, 2022).

Conclusion

This thesis looks at how the Chinese government connects national policies and media programs to shape how people understand AI. It sets the direction with official documents like the 2017 "New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan," the 2018 "Guiding Opinions on Intelligent Broadcasting," and the 2023 "Management Measures for Generative AI Services" (State Council, 2017; NRTA, 2018; CAC, 2023). These policies then become media content. One example is the "AI Gala," which turns these ideas into stories for the public. These documents create three levels of control. The first level gives a big-picture goal (Li, 2021; Yang & Huang, 2022). The second level explains how to use AI in different industries (Shi & Zhang, 2024). The third level sets rules about ethics and safety (Nachman, Chen, & Zhao, 2022; Romualdi, Girard, & Turgeon, 2025). In this system, AI is not only a tool for business and technology (Wang & Lin, 2024). It also helps manage media content. It becomes a way to share and support government values (Yu, Tay, & Yue, 2023; Pan, 2021).

The thesis combines quantitative analysis methods, including keyword frequency (see Table 1), discourse characteristics under the classification of actors (see Table 2), and co-occurrence of ideological vocabulary (see Table 3). These analyses clearly reveal how AI-related discourse is transmitted, reconstructed, and reproduced between policy and media. The conclusions of the study are consistent with previous studies on the centralization of China's AI governance structure and the synchronization of media expression (Zeng, Chan, & Schäfer, 2020; Zhao & Phakdeephirot, 2024). For example, the words used in the "AI Gala" are highly consistent with policy language, reflecting a deliberately designed "semantic engineering" - the purpose of this design is to create a seemingly natural but highly regulated digital discourse environment (Keane & Su, 2019; Rui, 2024). In this process, the program is both a cultural display and a practice of discourse shaping, packaging technological issues as national stories, and strengthening national identity (Dayan & Katz, 1992; Yu, 2009; Yu & Zeuthen, 2024).

This close connection also creates some tension. An obvious contradiction is that Chinese policies emphasize the "people-oriented" principle of AI, but in media content such as ceremonies, AI is often portrayed as almost autonomous or even superhuman (Bhatia, 2024; Franks, Lee, & Xu, 2024). The program rarely discusses issues such as labor substitution, surveillance expansion, or algorithmic bias, but tends to emphasize the positive side of technology. This "technological optimism" avoids the real ethical risks brought by AI (Samuel & Asare, 2024; Nachman et al., 2022). To address this divide, the 2023 Management Measures propose an ethical framework that requires all AI-generated content to reflect "socialist core values" and ensure that it does not deviate from the political mainline (CAC, 2023; Wang, 2022; Zhang et al., 2024).

Analysis of CCTV's 2025 program "Winning with AI+" adds important perspectives. Unlike the grand ceremony, this program adopts a more cautious tone and pays more attention to the ethical challenges and social impacts of AI. The host and experts discussed how to maintain a balance of "complementarity rather than replacement" in the relationship between humans and machines (CCTV, 2025). This shift suggests that China's state media is adjusting its strategy—from a single celebratory narrative to a more complex and self-reflective expression (Ping, 2020; Zhao, 2008; Jiang, Lan, Wang, & Zhang, 2023). This also verifies the view of scholars that China's public opinion control is not static, but can make tactical adjustments as the internal and external environment changes (Zeng, 2021; Wang, 2023).

Taken together, this thesis provides empirical support for understanding how AI is incorporated into China 's political discourse. It connects multiple research directions, including digital authoritarianism (Creemers, 2022; Feldstein, 2021), cultural governance (Zhao & Ye, 2023; McLaughlin, 2024), and AI ethics (Floridi & Cowls, 2019; Eubanks, 2018). The study shows that AI in China is not only a technological platform but also a political tool. This tool is systematically designed to combine policy language, media performance, and ideological communication to construct a "technological culture" that conforms to the governance logic of the party-state. In this culture, AI is a symbol of national modernization and a gatekeeper of social stability (Miao & Kang, 2023; Guo & Feng, 2012). Future research can continue to track how AI-generated content plays a role in a new round of large-scale communication projects, such as digital humans and virtual reality broadcasts. It is also possible to compare how China and other political systems deal with the ethical issues raised by AI, especially the issue of political boundaries in public communication (Jiang & Jia, 2023; Yang, 2009; Kwet, 2019).

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Appendix: Visualized Data Analysis and Coding Scheme

Table 1. Keyword Frequency in Policy Documents and AI Gala

Keyword (English)	AI Gala (Media)	Smart Broadcasting Policy (2018)	AI Development Plan (2017)	Generative AI Measures (2023)	Combined Total
AI (artificial intelligence)	158	5	314	39	516
Technology	23	40	148	19	230
Development	12	58	104	9	183
Innovation	5	31	76	6	118
Application	13	8	86	7	114
Safety	2	20	48	14	84
Ideology	0	1	0	0	1
"Smart Broadcasting"	0	47	0	0	47
"Smart City"	0	1	3	0	4
Industry	5	2	48	0	55
Talent	0	3	33	0	36
We	175	0	0	0	175
Culture	6	2	1	2	11
Future	26	1	4	0	31
Life	9	0	8	0	17

Note. This thesis conducted a keyword frequency analysis of the transcripts of the AI Gala and three important policy documents. The three documents are the "New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan" (2017), the "Guiding Opinions on Promoting the Development of Intelligent Broadcasting" (2018), and the "Interim Measures for the Management of Generative AI Services" (2023). We used the Chinese form of the keywords for statistics, for example, "AI" was unified as "人工智能" and "Technology" was counted as "技术". Across all sources, "人工智能" was the most frequently used word, indicating that this concept is at the core of both policy and media.

Table 2. Distribution of Discourse Features by Actor Category

Discourse Feature / Keyword	Government (Policy texts)	Media (AI Gala hosts/content)	Enterprise (Tech guest)	Expert (AI panelist)

Use of strategic tech terms ("technology", "industry", and "talent")	299 (high, cumulative across 2017–2023 policies)	30	10	12
Use of "we", inclusive pronoun	0	175 (high)	5	10
Emphasis on "safety/control"	83 (high)	2	1	1
Explicit ideological term "ideology"	1	0	0	0
Cultural references (historic figures, heritage)	5	25 (multiple segments)	2	3
Metaphorical/affective language	Low	High (e.g., "AI and humanity moving forward together")	Moderate	Moderate

Note. Comparison of discourse features used by different categories of actors: government (three policy documents combined), media (script and host of the AI Gala), and businesses and experts who spoke at the gala (e.g., tech company representatives and academic AI experts as guests). Bold numbers highlight the highest values in each row.

Table 3. Co-occurrence of Key Terms in Policy Documents vs. AI Gala

Terms Co-occurring	Frequency in Policy Documents (2017+2018+2023)	Frequency in AI Gala Transcript
AI & Development	38 (in policy texts)	8 (in gala)
AI & Technology	36	14
AI & Application	29	10
AI & Innovation	27	5
Technology & Development	18	6
Technology & Application	24	3
Development & Innovation	14	2
AI & Future	9	26 (notably high)

AI & Life	4	17 (notably high)
AI & Safety	15	2

Note. This thesis compares three policy documents (the 2017 AI Development Plan, the 2018 Smart Broadcasting Guidelines, and the 2023 Generative AI Service Management Measures) with the transcripts of the AI Gala, analyzing the co-occurrence frequency between keywords. "Co-occurrence" here refers to the number of times two keywords appear together in the same paragraph (policy) or the same segment (gala).

Keyword Coding Scheme

A systematic text analysis required the development of a coding scheme which divided key terms into thematic categories for classification purposes. The below table represents a coding scheme with categories, subcategories, the specific keywords along with their English translations along with definitions and analysis coding notations:

Category	Subcategory	Keyword (Term) & Definition	Code
Core AI Concepts	General Concept	人工智能 (AI) – Refers to artificial intelligence as a whole, including the abbreviation "AI". Encompasses discussions of AI technology and field broadly.	Core-AI (A1)
	Sector-Specific	智慧广电 (Smart Broadcasting) – Refers to the concept of "intelligent broadcasting," integrating AI into broadcasting. A policy term denoting modernization of radio/TV with AI.	Core-AI (A2)
Technology & Application	General Tech & Use	技术 (Technology) – General term for technology, often indicating advanced or core technologies in context. 应用 (Application) – Use or application of technology (usually AI) in practical scenarios or industries.	Tech/App (B1); Tech/App (B2)
	Specific Technologies	大数据 (Big Data) – Refers to large-scale data analytics and datasets, often mentioned as part of AI ecosystem. 机器人 (Robot/Robotics) – Physical AI-driven robots or the	Tech/App (B3); Tech/App (B4)

		field of robotics. Indicates AI embodied in machines or robots.	
National Strategy	Development & Innovation	发展 (Development) – Economic and social development; progress, often in context of national development goals. 创 新 (Innovation) – Technological or scientific innovation; creating new advancements (a key goal in policy). 产 业 (Industry) – Industry/industrial sector, often referring to developing an AI industry or related industries.	Strategy (C1); Strategy (C2); Strategy (C3)
	Security & Talent	安 全 (Security) – Primarily national security or safety in tech context; protecting interests through AI and ensuring secure development. 人才 (Talent) – Human talent; skilled professionals or workforce (especially developing AI experts and labor force).	Strategy (C4); Strategy (C5)

Note. A code system was established for classifying discourse types. The explanations define and contextualize each keyword term. Designated specific labels (Core-AI(A1)) for analyzing occurrences of "人工智能" during the analysis process. The analytical scheme functioned as a guide for analyzing text frequency and co-occurrence patterns to maintain theme consistency in the analysis process.

All keywords used for analysis were included when they played key roles in frequency and co-occurrence measurement. The definitions adapt to the role that terms play within the texts. AI as a concept was included in coding sessions when AI appeared either as 人工智能 or its English name AI. The code 智慧广电 functioned only when used directly in broadcasting policy discussions.